Raimon Panikkar, and what 'philosophy' is comparative philosophy comparing?

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Abstract

In this short text, I offer an analysis of an essay by Raimon Panikkar that continues to be greatly influential in comparative philosophy circles. My goal is not so much to cover the entire opera omnia *of Panikkar in a comprehensive manner, nor to do justice to him as a person and scholar (I admittedly fail in both regards), but to bring out into the open what in his essay 'on comparative philosophy' is only implicitly present, what is presumed but not explicated, and what perhaps only those well versed in his other works will immediately understand. In view of the fact that those working within comparative philosophy have come to appreciate Panikkar's essay as a contribution to the self-understanding and methodology of the discipline, I venture to argue that this is, if anything, a misreading of what the essay is about (whether it is a productive misreading is another question). Panikkar is pursuing his philosophical-*qua-*religious agenda in the form of imparative philosophy, which he recommends as a superior type of comparative philosophy. My main contention is that Panikkar's recommendation falls short, both on the level of argumentation as well as on the level of the imperatives of "imparative "philosophy itself.*

In his Gifford Lectures, *The Rhythm of Being*, Raimon Panikkar writes that "we all think within a given *mythos*", of which we cannot extricate ourselves, not entirely that is – for if we were able to do so the myth would no longer persist, no longer be our myth, no longer be the one within which we think[1]. I agree, and hence should like to begin with some remarks about the myth from within which the following thoughts take their starting-point, knowing that I cannot but must fail to characterize my myth entirely from without. The narcissist character of such a beginning is hereby acknowledged and may perhaps be excused by its specific purpose of signaling what is a substantial and far-reaching incompatibility between Panikkar's and my own myth.

My own myth would be variously described by Panikkar as that of an 'unbeliever', someone pursuing 'conceptual arithmetic' and being a 'monoculturalist' – in short, of a child of modern science and culture[2]. I would agree, more or less at least.

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[1] R. Panikkar, *The Rhythm of Being* (The Gifford Lectures), Orbis Books, Maryknoll, NY 2010, 114.

[2] R. Panikkar, *The Rhythm of Being*, cit., passim. For 'monoculturalist', see: R. Panikkar, "Religion, Philosophy and Culture", trans. Robert Vachon, *polylog: Forum for Intercultural Philosophy* 1 (2000), online: http://goo.gl/NKBw3 (4.1.2013).

Panikkar's myth on the other hand meets the self-description of proceeding from within an 'intercultural' and a believing though anti-monotheistic, but beatific and even salvific mythos, based on symbolic rather than conceptual thinking. There is little doubt when Panikkar sets out at the end of his Gifford Lectures to describe 'the emerging mythos', which he believes the modern world is in dire need of, that this myth is largely if not completely congruent with Panikkar's own 'cosmotheandric' myth. I cannot give you my reasons, but simply will admit that I can make neither head nor tail of the 'saving vision' that is outlined in *The Rhythm of Being* – to a degree that I think warrants my use of the word 'incompatibility' in qualifying the difference between Panikkar's and my own myth[3].

Hence, it would seem that there is no way that Panikkar and I could enter into fruitful dialogue, let alone 'dialogical dialogue', but this is exactly what I should like to attempt and I think it possible because of an essay that he has written many years ago and published in 1988 in what is still an authoritative edited volume in the discipline of comparative philosophy. It is an essay that he first presented at the 1984 meeting of the *Society of Asian and Comparative Philosophy* in Hawai'i with the wonderful title: "What is comparative philosophy comparing?"[4] It features no subtitles, but it is clearly divided in three main parts together with short introductory and concluding passages.

The essay begins with a short introductory comment on the problematic fashionableness of comparative studies understood as a political instrument of 'the West' for control of the "global picture of the world", a picture that "comparative philosophy" in spite of its "in-built trend to overcome" plurality might well end up undermining by "legitimizing mutually irreconcilable systems"[5]. Also right at the beginning, Panikkar gives his main thesis that "strictly speaking, comparative philosophy is an impossible independent discipline, which nevertheless strives in the very recognition of its impossibility"[6].

In the first part of the essay (pp. 116-120), Panikkar is concerned with showing that the discipline of comparative philosophy is impossible. The claim that comparative philosophy is "an independent discipline […], which liberates us from the limited horizons of one single philosophical view" is rejected as an "illusion"[7]. Repeatedly

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[3] For some rightly sceptical remarks on Panikkar's cosmotheandrism vis-à-vis modern science in what generally is an appreciative discussion of his works, cf. J. Prabhu, "Lost in Translation: Panikkar's Intercultural Odyssey" in J. Prabhu (ed.), *The Intercultural Challenge of Raimon Panikkar*, Orbis Books, Maryknoll, NY 1996, 18-19.

[4] R. Panikkar, "What is comparative philosophy comparing?" in G.J. Larson and E. Deutsch (eds), *Interpreting Across Boundaries: New Essays in Comparative Philosophy*, Princeton University Press, Princeton 1988, 116-136.

[5] R. Panikkar, "What is comparative philosophy comparing?", cit., 116.

[6] *Ibid.*

[7] *Ibid.*, 118.

asking the question what kind of philosophy comparative philosophy is and what status this very question has, Panikkar comes to point out a sort of Russell's paradox, what he calls a 'dilemma', since comparative philosophy seems to dither between being a meta-philosophy that amounts to yet 'another philosophy' (i.e. contained in the set of philosophies) and being a philosophy standing qualitatively apart from all other philosophies (i.e. not contained in the set) and 'passing judgment' on them – hence the putative impossibility[8].

In the second and central part (pp. 120-130), Panikkar is concerned with showing that the discipline of comparative philosophy impossibly is independent and he examines five types of contemporary relevance: (I) transcendental philosophy, (II) formal or structural philosophy, (III) linguistic philosophy, (IV) phenomenological philosophy, and his own (V) dialogical or imparative philosophy. None of these types, he writes, 'ultimately' offers "a satisfactory basis for a truly independent comparative philosophy"[9], but imparative philosophy in Panikkar's view is to be preferred since it stresses "an open philosophical attitude ready to learn from whatever philosophical corner of the world, but without claiming to compare philosophies from an objective, neutral, and transcendent vantage point"[10]. Further invested with a decidedly "critical" consciousness, imparative philosophy promises a way towards a "philosophical pluralism" that has overcome "provincially chauvinist views"[11].

In the third part (pp. 130-134), Panikkar enquires into the question of a method appropriate to imparative philosophy and introduces his 'diatopical hermeneutics' as an answer to the question. The hermeneutical challenge of gaining understanding across the boundaries of 'two (or more) cultures' is in Panikkar's description only gradually different from intra-cultural philosophical boundaries, but still different to such a degree that a different method is warranted since we find ourselves "under a different mythos or horizon of intelligibility"[12]. Also using the word 'symbol' in these passages, Panikkar is here hinting at major themes developed in more detail in his others works, including *The Rhythm of Being* (the original lectures were given in 1989). It is by means of 'primordial symbols' that we "know what is existentially important" and "come to know also other things"[13]. Finally, being epistemologically equipped with symbols, we may engage in 'dialogical dialogue' by which 'mutual comprehension', 'cross[ing] the

[8] *Ibid.*, 120.
[9] *Ibid.*, 122.
[10] *Ibid.*, 127.
[11] *Ibid.*, 129.
[12] *Ibid.*, 130.
[13] *Ibid.*, 132.

boundaries' and "the forging of a common universe of discourse" become real possibilities[14]. This is all but easy, Panikkar assures us, for

> only those persons who […] have existentially crossed the borders of at least two cultures and are home in either, shall be able first to understand and then to translate[15].

The essay's concluding remarks return to the political introduction and take up the thesis of the impossible independent discipline of comparative philosophy. That discipline is now said to aim at comparing "the final myths on which certain cultures have constructed their worlds"[16], with the major appendix that this includes 'the West' and its myth(s). It is thus that comparative philosophy is said not to 'demythologize' but to 'transmythicize'[17]. Panikkar is issuing a fundamental criticism not only of philosophy, but also of comparative philosophy as hitherto practiced as a "superphilosophy of the modern western critical mind, passing judgment on everything under the sun, uncritical of its own assumptions and of what philosophy is"[18]. Comparative philosophy qua imparative philosophy therefore is not independent superphilosophy, not passing judgment but "contrasting everything and learning from everywhere", and always critical of its own assumptions and of what philosophy is – in fact, it is said to be 'radically' critical of its own enterprise[19].

This is the entry point for my dialogue with Panikkar and I shall now proceed to my criticism of his essay and his take on comparative philosophy. Put in admittedly provocative terms, I argue that Panikkar's argument is pitting a more than vague imparative philosophy against caricatures of other types of comparative philosophy. He thus fails to live up to his own admonition of taking other philosophical views seriously.

My criticism is twofold, one on the level of argumentation and one on the level of the imperatives of imparative philosophy measured against its own assumptions. First to some criticism of how Panikkar argues his case: consider how in the essay five types of contemporary comparative philosophy are distinguished and discussed, all eventually *failing* to constitute a 'truly independent comparative philosophy', while one, imparative philosophy, still emerges at the end as the *recommendable* option. What is the exact relation between the failure of all five types and the positive assessment of one of them? What criteria are used to decide on failure and recommendation? Quite obviously, that which makes all five types fail cannot be that which justifies the recommendation of imparative philosophy. Otherwise imparative philosophy would

[14] *Ibid.*.
[15] *Ibid.*, 133.
[16] *Ibid.*, 134.
[17] *Ibid.*
[18] *Ibid.*, 135.
[19] *Ibid.*, 136.

turn out to be recommended and considered a failure for the very same reason. Not to be mistaken, the problem would not be the apparent contradiction; at least it would not be a problem for Panikkar who rejects the logical law of non-contradiction[20]. The problem would rather be that it would be left entirely unclear why not all five types but only imparative philosophy were allowed the benefit of contradiction.

In my view, however, there are clearly different criteria at work when Panikkar determines failure and embraces recommendation. This brings up at least two possible constellations for further enquiry, if we keep within the five offered types and disregard the important question whether there are other types of comparative philosophy, perhaps stronger candidates for types than those listed by Panikkar. The first constellation regards criteria for failure. Does Panikkar offer reasons of failure for each other type of comparative philosophy beyond the commonly shared failure of not constituting a 'truly independent comparative philosophy'? The second constellation regards criteria for recommendation. Are Panikkar's reasons for recommending imparative philosophy based on criteria that are not applicable to the other types of comparative philosophy or, if applicable, do they yield opposite answers? In short, Panikkar's argumentation falls short with regard to both inquiries.

For instance, discussing transcendental philosophy Panikkar concludes that despite being a 'valid critical philosophy' and possibly embracing the 'most comprehensive' 'conception of philosophy' it eventually fails for its partiality and lack of fairness "to the philosophies compared"; further, such transcendental philosophy will not be embraced by "some of them" as it is based "on a scale of values they do not recognize"[21]. Partiality cannot really be the problem, for imparative philosophy itself can no less ever come to be sure to have escaped partiality, as Panikkar himself readily admits when highlighting "the contingencies of its own assumptions and the unavoidable necessity of resting on both limited and still unexamined presuppositions"[22]. The problem hence seems to be the non-recognition of a 'scale of values' which is not shared, not held in common. But here Panikkar simply seems to confuse matters, for he pits his promise of imparative philosophy as eventually possibly achieving a 'common universe of discourse' against the description of transcendental philosophy, the *goal* of imparative philosophy against the *practice* of transcendental philosophy. There is no reason why transcendental philosophy should not receive an equally charitable treatment; its goal surely is not partiality, but literally a transcendentality devoid of it, which may also lay claim to constitute a 'common universe of discourse'. Imparative philosophy as one of the five types precisely rests on the assumption that the scale of values embraced by various philosophies differs, even to the point of incommensurability.

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[20] Cf. R. Panikkar, *The Rhythm of Being*, cit., 118-120.

[21] R. Panikkar, "What is comparative philosophy comparing?", cit., 123.

[22] *Ibid.*, 128.

Also if we look at the criteria for recommendation (apart from the mentioned promise), there are problems. Panikkar singles out the (self) critical, reflective, open-minded, and learning character of imparative philosophy and its disclaimer over against the aim of a 'transcendent vantage point'[23]. But there is no reason why any of the other types of comparative philosophy could not assume such an attitude or issue such a disclaimer. As a matter of fact, I simply fail to see why from among all those many philosophers pursuing these other types many would not – in ideal at least – want to embrace a (self) critical, reflective, open-minded and learning attitude or would positively append to their universalist claims the label of provisionality. To the extent that Panikkar does not even consider this option, he fails to take other philosophical views seriously – which is what imparative philosophy is said to be all about.

This brings me to my second criticism, the one on the level of the imperatives of imparative philosophy measured against its own assumptions. One such imperative is to subject "everything to a critical scrutiny with all available tools of analysis"[24]. What I intend to do is to offer a very simple tool of analysis and to subject Panikkar's essay to a critical scrutiny, particularly his understanding of philosophy. I derive my tool of analysis from a simple set of elements that analytically can be distinguished in just any comparison: A comparison is always done by someone, two or more *comparata* are being compared, they are being compared in a certain common respect (since the late 17th century referred to as the *tertium comparationis*), and comparison, if concluded, has an outcome, often expressed in terms of a relation. To this, as I discuss elsewhere, should be added a fifth element, which emphasizes the act of selecting the *comparata*, which are chosen for comparison because they are somehow considered related or are at least related by the very fact that they are laid one next to the other for comparison. That relation on some level includes a commonality that I have called the 'pre-comparative *tertium*'. The 'pre-comparative *tertium*' and the *tertium comparationis* are related and mutually informing inasmuch as any respect in which two *comparata* may be compared denotes a (potential or actual) commonality that may but need not be part of the commonality that motivates the selection of the *comparata* and *vice versa* – which is why it might be helpful to distinguish the two elements[25].

Let me give a quick example. If I set out to compare, say, the philosophies of Confucius and Aristotle, then I presuppose or assert on the level of the 'pre-comparative *tertium*' that both Confucius and Aristotle had a philosophy or might usefully be looked at as having had a philosophy. If, in the course of comparison, the philosophies are compared for their theories of virtue, then it is presumed on the level of the *tertium comparationis* that they had (or that it might be useful to look at them as if they had)

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[23] *Ibid.*, 127.

[24] *Ibid.*, 128.

[25] Cf. R. Weber, "Comparative philosophy and the *tertium*: comparing what with what, and in what respect?", *Dao: A Journal of Comparative Philosophy*, 2014, forthcoming.

theories and also one about virtue. Importantly, the choice of *tertium comparationis*, of having a theory of virtue, is thus related back to the 'pre-comparative *tertium*' and qualifies what it means to have a philosophy. If the entire comparison is entitled as one between the philosophies of Confucius and Aristotle in regard of their theories of virtue, then having had theories and one about virtue might likely be a commonality that motivated the selection of the *comparata* and thus may (also) be part of the 'pre-comparative *tertium*' more straightforwardly. Much more might of course be presupposed in the selection of these *tertia*, and all of that may be left implicit or vague. But distinguishing and focusing on these elements may serve as a tool of analysis helping to make the implicit more explicit, i.e. in casu Panikkar's concept of philosophy in his comparison of different types of comparative philosophy.

Panikkar is explicit in that "from the name itself"[26] comparative philosophy is about comparing philosophies[27]. And his 'working definition' accordingly portrays comparative philosophy as "the philosophical study of one or some problems in the light of more than one tradition"[28]. Here, the 'pre-comparative *tertium*' of philosophies is qualified by the emphasis on 'problems' on the one hand and by the introduction of 'traditions' as a somehow meaningful unity for philosophical study. Analyzing Panikkar's text along these lines with a view to qualifications to his concept of philosophy obviously brings forth a long list. Here is what I have found, sometimes preceded by the adjective 'philosophical' or followed by the *genitivus subjectivus* 'of philosophies': problems, traditions, wisdom of other cultures, systems or systems of thought, views or stances, schools, self-understandings, scale of values, inner dynamism, cultural insights, worldviews, experiences of people, ultimate truths, universes of discourse, languages, and so on and so forth. How all of these terms relate is left entirely to the reader to find out. Does one language amount to one people? Can a culture possibly sport several traditions, several schools, or several scales of values? If so, what does that mean for philosophy, which at one or another point in the argument is related to all of these terms? Panikkar is not giving us any answer to these questions.

In the third part of the essay, when talking about diatopical hermeneutics, Panikkar makes it fully clear that from among the list the mention of 'cultures' is the major qualification of philosophy. Cultures represent an important dividing line for different philosophies, which is evident when he writes that:

> the distance between two (or more) cultures, which have independently developed in different spaces (*topoi*) their own methods of philosophizing and ways of reaching intelligibility along with their proper categories[29]

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[26] *Ibid.*, 118.

[27] In one instance, though, he slips into writing 'philosophers' instead of 'philosophies', cf. 118.

[28] R. Panikkar, *The Rhythm of Being*, cit., 121-122.

[29] R. Panikkar, "What is comparative philosophy comparing?", cit., 130.

thus adding a series of qualifications to my list above. *Topoi* mentioned in the essay include India, China, Africa, Greece and the West, but how they relate again is left to the reader to decide. To be clear, Panikkar is certainly not alone in taking cultural difference to imply philosophical difference, but nowhere in the essay is there a single argument why that ought to be so; nor is there a critical reflection of the contingences that have brought cultures onto the agenda in the first place. In other words, all of that is uncritically assumed to be the case.

There is a second revealing passage in which Panikkar talks about "bringing one culture, language, philosophy into another culture, language, or religion, making it understandable"[30]. Here is it unclear how culture, language, philosophy and religion relate to each other and why it is that philosophy is substituted for religion – but the fact that it is substituted is surely telling. Religion as a term does not feature prominently in this specific essay of Panikkar. In his description of imparative philosophy, he mentions the importance of the awareness

> that most philosophies regard themselves as unique and often as ultimate. Thus we cannot justifiably compare, that is, bring together (*com*) on an equal (*par*) footing, that which purports to be unique and uncomparable[31].

This to me is an odd statement, for I cannot come up with any one philosophy which would hold such claims. Instead the language of ultimacy, uniqueness and incomparability is more often used in the context of religions and substituting religions for philosophies in the above statement would remove much of the oddity – if viewed from the myth from within which I have admitted to be thinking. For Panikkar, things are different; philosophy and religion are inseparable, which is a view that can be defended, but is not defended, let alone made explicit in this essay[32]. He has of course made it explicit and defended it elsewhere, e.g. at length in his *A Dwelling Place for Wisdom* or in the Gifford Lectures[33]. But when reading *The Rhythm of Being* and

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[30] *Ibid.*, 133.

[31] *Ibid.*, 127.

[32] The language of inseparability is not only mine but also Panikkar's, for, albeit in another text, he is quick to state that "religion and culture cannot be separated", which raises the question again how, culture, religion and, *per implicationem*, philosophy relate to each other. Cf. R. Panikkar, "A Self-Critical Dialogue", in J. Prabhu (ed.), *The Intercultural Challenge of Raimon Panikkar*, cit., 243.

[33] Here are some relevant passages: "To me, philosophy is just as much the wisdom of love as it is the love of wisdom. And true love is not only spontaneous but also ecstatic – that is, nonreflective. It does not revert to a critical analysis of itself. […] Then authentic philosophy will crystallize into a life-style. To say it better, primal philosophy becomes the expression of life itself as articulated to reality or, rather, as written down with a *stylus* (a pen), the style of one's personal life. In my opinion, the kind of philosophy that solely deals with structures, theories, ideas; the one shying away from life, circumventing the

analyzing the concept of philosophy in it along with my tool of analysis, an even much longer list than the one offered above results (adding for instance civilizations, forms of life, etc.), while nothing of the vagueness is dispelled.

Myth, which is the single most central notion in the Gifford Lectures and the notion with which I began this essay, also appears at the end of Panikkar's essay on comparative philosophy and it appears in a characterization of comparative philosophy that I have quoted above but wish to quote again in conclusion. Panikkar writes that "what comparative philosophy tries to compare are the final myths on which certain cultures have constructed their worlds"[34]. Would he have used this religious and mythological understanding of philosophy and of comparative philosophy, which is much more specific than his 'working definition', the other types of comparative philosophy would never have come to figure as serious alternative options in the first place. In Panikkar's argument, they are really nothing but a red herring.

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practical aspect, and repressing feelings, is one-sided, because it does not touch upon other aspects of reality, and because of that, it is poor. Reality as such cannot be grasped, comprehended and *realized* by a single sense organ or by only one of reality's dimensions. Such an approach would turn philosophy merely into another science – perhaps a more general science, a new form of algebra – but it would destroy philosophy as *wisdom* and prevent philosophy from expressing itself in human life-style. […] The influence of the natural sciences on philosophy and on philosophical method has been so decisive that today not only academic philosophy itself but also ecclesiastical theology has become a special branch with special sub-branches. In the process, wisdom was either lost or degraded to an uncritical, naïve – if not primitive – contentedness with the world. […] The traditional name given to a mentality that is clairvoyant, critical, intellectual, and equally spontaneous, free, and existential, is wisdom – also, philosophy. If we do not restore harmony between this split, our civilization will go under. My philosophical desire is to offer a convincing alternative to the destructive schizophrenia of our prevalently technocratic culture." Cf. R. Panikkar, *A Dwelling Place for Wisdom*, trans. Annemarie S. Kidder, Motilal Banarsidass, Delhi, 1993, 88-89.

[34] R. Panikkar, "What is comparative philosophy comparing?", cit., 134.